covered. The upcoming winter session of Parliament is expected to address this oversight through comprehensive amendments. "We are constantly monitoring [the situation], the MHA is also monitoring it, and the airlines are in constant touch with us. Everybody is on the same platform," says Naidu, adding that the proposed amendments have been sent for inter-ministerial inputs.

The catalyst for these reforms emerged in mid-October when a now-suspended social media account launched a systematic campaign of threats against both domestic and international carriers. The scope was alarming: 12 threats on October 18 escalated to 34 the following day, targeting airlines including Vistara, Air India, IndiGo, Akasa and international operators like Star Air and JetBlue. Adding a dire edge to these was a warning from US/Canada-based Khalistani ideologue Gurpatwant Singh Pannun against flying Air India on November 1-19.

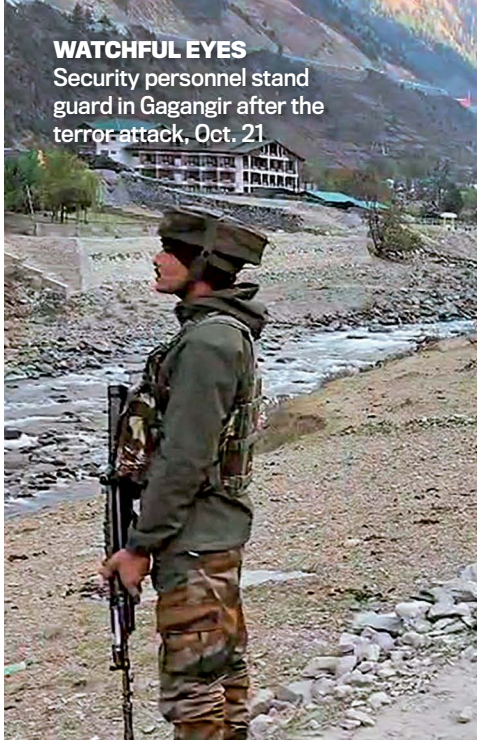
Each incident triggered the International Civil Aviation Organisation's rigorous protocol: aircraft diversion, isolation, passenger evacuation and thorough security sweeps. Days earlier, on October 14, Air India's New York-bound flight from Mumbai had to make an emergency landing in Delhi following a similar bomb scare. On October 20-22, IndiGo alone faced threats on 29 flights, including international routes to Istanbul and Dammam. A Vistara Delhi-London flight was also forced to land in Frankfurt. Officials concerned at the aviation establishments believe several of these could be just "copycats". "But we cannot take any threat lightly," says a senior official, on the condition of anonymity. "What if flooding us with these false threats is a way of lowering our guard? No one wants to take that chance."

These disruptions extract an enormous toll. Industry analysts estimate that each diversion costs the already financially bleeding airlines several lakhs of rupees in fuel alone, with total losses potentially reaching multiple crores per incident. The challenge is further complicated by the digital nature of these threats. Naidu acknowledges that perpetrators using Virtual Private Networks (VPNs) can mask their locations, making enforcement particularly complex. In one disturbing instance, threats were posted under a handle referencing a 2012 mass shooting in the US though the Mumbai police have since apprehended a 17-year-old suspect in Chhattisgarh in connection with some of the threats.

The government has responded with a "10 per cent increase" in security protocols and enhanced CCTV monitoring at terminals. Meanwhile, civil aviation officials are collaborating with the ministry of electronics and information technology (MeITY) to develop more robust countermeasures against the digital threats. As India's aviation industry prepares for this new regulatory framework, it faces a delicate balancing act: maintaining rigorous security standards to guarantee safety of passengers while ensuring minimum inconvenience. ■

THE MEASURES

- **Changes in Aircraft Security Rules to put offenders on no-fly list**
- **Amendments to provide for five years to life imprisonment for false bomb threats, even if emanating from outside airport**
- **Enhanced security protocols and CCTV monitoring at terminals**



WATCHFUL EYES Security personnel stand guard in Gagangir after the terror attack, Oct. 21

JAMMU & KASHMIR

NEW TARGET OF TERROR

By Kaleem Geelani

On October 20, as dusk fell in the Gagangir area of central Kashmir's Ganderbal district, terrorists opened fire on workers returning to their camp from the Z-Morh tunnel construction site, killing six of them as well as a doctor, and injuring several others. The workers—mostly migrant—were engaged on a project of strategic value. The tunnel connects Sonamarg with Kangan town on the Srinagar-Leh highway, a vital supply route to the Line of Actual Control (LAC) in Ladakh.

The incident marks the first assault on a key infrastructure project in the five years since the abrogation of Article 370 in August 2019. It also occurred just four days after Chief Minister Omar Abdullah assumed leadership of the first Union Territory govern-